purposes, yet today, drugs have spread like cancer, even at the school games' competition levels. Visit any educational institution in the Punjab, and you will find needles and other substance abuse paraphernalia lying around openly. Drugs are easily available either in medical stores or through dealers, and each person, whether a child or adult, knows what drug to take, when and how much. Up-and-coming young athletes have no qualms about taking any type of illegal substances, whether it is heroin, cocaine, or banned supplement drugs to enhance their performances to achieve spectacular results without hard work. The authorities are aware of what is taking place, so are the coaches and doctors who pretend that they don't. In the last few years, there has been a spate of scandals regarding the use of drugs among Indian sportspeople.

Two members of the Indian women's 4x400-metre relay team who won gold medals at the Delhi Commonwealth Games in 2010, later tested positive for the use of performance-enhancing steroids; more recently was the unexpected allegation that Olympic bronze-medallist, Vijender Singh, had taken heroin and other banned substances, though the tests turned out to be negative. Despite the personal humiliation and disgrace of medals being returned and dishonour to the country, no action has been taken to stop the spread of drugs. If the government and sports authorities are serious about the eradication of illegal drugs, they must act swiftly and enforce a strict clampdown on all the sources and suppliers; ban athletes who take drugs from participating in future events, and suspend or sack doctors and coaches who are responsible for importing drugs or introducing them to their students. Strong, almost authoritarian, measures are the only ways in which to deal with such serious and harmful practices.

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In 2001, the Bharatiya Janata Party government offered me the Arjuna Award, almost forty years after I had received the more prestigious Padma Shri in 1958. When the award was introduced in 1961, its premise was very clear—that it would only be granted to those outstanding sportspeople who had received medals in international events, including the Olympic, Asian and Commonwealth games.

When I looked at the list I discovered that it included even team members for games which have no global presence like kabbadi, which is